ELECTRIC LAND GATE STRATEGY

Competitor map, capital deployment, customer acquisition, founder positioning, and scale plan

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This brief gives the competitor analysis the most depth and keeps the operating recommendations concise. The strategic premise is that Synchronicity should enter as a service and evidence-orchestration company, not as an engineering firm, broker, or speculative land fund.

Executive conclusion

- Competition exists at almost every gate. Paces and LandGate already automate parcel screening and diligence; DC Byte sells market/infrastructure intelligence; major engineering firms perform technical diligence; global brokerages combine site selection, power, transactions and capital markets; Tract actually acquires and conditions powered land.
- The opening is narrower: own the cross-disciplinary decision record. Define the buyer requirement, kill false positives, route specialist questions, preserve provenance/transferability, monitor evidence expiration, and identify the cheapest next proof.
- The Arizona screen shows the problem: capacity was unknown for 248/255 candidates, utility assignment was ambiguous for 181/255, candidates were infrastructure points rather than confirmed parcels, and high water scores measured regulatory freedom rather than physical water.
- Do not rent an office or hire employees to manufacture credibility. Add fixed cost only when recurring work makes it operationally useful.

Competitive landscape

Competitor/class	Current offering	Where it overlaps	Implication
Paces	Parcel search, power-ready siting, withdrawal-capacity heatmaps, fiber/gas, Critical Issues Analysis, power-flow studies, owner information, origination.	Gates 1-3 and parts of 5-7.	Closest software/service competitor. Do not build another generic map dashboard.
LandGate	Buildability, interconnection planning, environmental reports, proprietary power/offtake data, diligence reports, marketplace.	Gates 1-3, 5, 8-9.	Compete on verification and evidence workflow, or buy/license data.
DC Byte	Data-center market, tenant/hyperscaler, project, power/fiber and supplier intelligence.	Gate 1 and buyer intelligence.	Use it to understand demand; differentiate on parcel execution.
Tract	Acquires land; prepositions power/fiber; secures zoning/entitlements; engages communities; sells shovel-ready campuses.	Long-term end state.	Potential customer now; formidable direct competitor later.
Atwell / AECOM / Stantec / Black & Veatch / Kimley-Horn / Burns & McDonnell	Site feasibility, fatal-flaw diligence, utility outreach, civil/geotech/environmental work, permitting, conceptual engineering, power/water.	Gates 2-8.	Be the early client-side orchestrator; do not imitate licensed engineering.
CBRE / JLL / Cushman & Wakefield / Colliers	Site selection, land acquisition/disposition, power procurement, market intelligence, entitlements, financing and transactions.	Gates 1, 4, 8-10.	Avoid unlicensed brokerage; differentiate through transaction-neutral red-team evidence.

Gate 0 - Project definition and kill criteria

Gate question: Is the project defined precisely enough to evaluate sites?

Verdict: Enter immediately; low-risk learning wedge.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
AECOM / engineering firms	Owner requirements, utility demand, schedule/budget inputs.	Medium	Offer a faster pre-engineering requirements sprint.
Brokerage advisers	Translate occupier requirements into location strategy.	Medium	Make assumptions explicit enough to drive every later gate.
Paces/LandGate	Project filters and scenario inputs.	Low-medium	Human interview + signed assumptions register before software.

Capital deployment

- Spend $1k-$5k on templates, secure storage and senior expert review.
- No full-time engineer; buy 5-10 hours of expert calibration.

Customer acquisition

- Target merchant developers, industrial developers, infrastructure investors and economic-development groups.
- Sell a fixed-fee Project Requirements Sprint before land search.

How to sell this gate

- "Before we search land, we define what would make a site fail."
- Show how a vague 200 MW requirement becomes utility-ready questions.

What the company looks like

- Solo founder from home/apartment; expert bench on contract.
- Assets are the method, CRM, clean website and data room.

Gate 1 - Regional and utility-territory feasibility

Gate question: Which markets and utility regimes deserve attention?

Verdict: Selective entry. Generic national screening is crowded; local verification is more defensible.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
Paces	Power-ready search, heatmaps, grid/fiber/gas screening.	High	Local verification and process intelligence.
LandGate	Capacity/site analysis and portfolio screening.	High	Utility-specific workflow and evidence provenance.
DC Byte	Market, tenant, hyperscaler and infrastructure intelligence.	High on market layer	Combine demand-side intelligence with local readiness.
CBRE/C&W/JLL/Colliers	Market comparison, power, labor, incentives, site strategy.	High	Focus on overlooked Western utility regimes and smaller buyers.

Capital deployment

- Spend $3k-$15k on data, GIS, travel/calls and expert validation.
- Build a verified utility/process library rather than recreating national datasets.

Customer acquisition

- Sell portfolio screens before customers spend on site control.
- Outbound with a concrete thesis: three territories deserve calls; seven do not.

How to sell this gate

- Never say "AI finds hidden capacity." Say "we separate public-data signals from utility-confirmed facts."
- Use Arizona utility ambiguity as a proof-of-problem.

What the company looks like

- Founder-led; freelance GIS analyst only against paid workload.
- Coworking is enough; no dedicated office.

Gate 2 - Parcel desktop fatal-flaw screen

Gate question: Does a parcel survive ownership, buildability, infrastructure and hazard screening?

Verdict: Core early product; crowded but viable on speed, transparency and discipline.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
Paces	Critical Issues Analysis and parcel/interconnection/environmental risk.	Very high	Independent evidence grading + human follow-up.
LandGate	Buildability, setbacks, GIS, interconnection and environmental reports.	Very high	Buyer-specific kill criteria and cross-source audit trail.
Engineering firms	Detailed site diligence and fatal-flaw analysis.	Very high	Cheaper pre-professional screen before field work.
Brokerages	Site selection and preliminary diligence.	High	Be willing to recommend no transaction.

Capital deployment

- Spend $5k-$20k on parcel/title data, GIS and professional review.
- Price jobs to allow escalation to experts when a question becomes engineering/legal/environmental.

Customer acquisition

- Offer a 5-10 business-day Kill Screen on a site already under consideration.
- Developers/investors are better initial customers than landowners because they benefit from defects.

How to sell this gate

- "Our job is to find the reason not to spend the next $100,000."
- Lead with a one-page red/yellow/green decision sheet.

What the company looks like

- Founder + contractors. First hire at ~$20k-$25k monthly revenue for three months: research/GIS analyst.
- Two-person Tucson office only after that hire and ~6 months runway.

Gate 3 - Human validation and ground truth

Gate question: Do utilities, governments, providers and the physical site support the desktop theory?

Verdict: Strong differentiator because public data cannot replace institutional memory.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
Engineering firms	Utility outreach, agency coordination, site inspections.	High	Standardized call/evidence record.
Brokerages	Relationships with utilities/local government and off-market sourcing.	High	Transaction-neutral audit trail.
Tract	Direct community, utility and	High at scale	Narrow-territory speed and local

	government engagement.		memory.
Software firms	Data identifies targets but cannot replace all human verification.	Medium	Make human validation a product.

Capital deployment

- Spend $3k-$15k on travel, CRM, public records, local consultants and expert attendance.
- A named contact and documented answer is more valuable than premium office space.

Customer acquisition

- Sell verification sprints after a desktop screen.
- Ask a buyer for one site it distrusts; return dated confirmations and unresolved questions.

How to sell this gate

- "Do not trust my intuition; audit the evidence."
- Never posture as having utility influence.

What the company looks like

- Founder + analyst + expert bench.
- Small Tucson office becomes reasonable around $300k-$500k annualized revenue if it improves coordination.

Gate 4 - Site control and diligence rights

Gate question: Can the customer control land conditionally while diligence proceeds?

Verdict: Coordination product now; direct transaction economics only after licensing/partnership and capital.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
CBRE/JLL/C&W/Colliers/brokers	Acquisition, disposition and transaction negotiation.	Very high	Coordinate diligence without unlicensed brokerage.
Real-estate counsel	Options, PSAs, easements, title and closing conditions.	High licensed work	Issue lists, diligence schedules and evidence requirements.
Tract	Acquires and controls land directly.	Direct long-term	Do not compete on balance sheet yet.

Capital deployment

- Spend $5k-$25k on outside real-estate counsel, title and transaction templates.
- Do not put meaningful option capital at risk until paid customer demand and utility/planning validation exist.

Customer acquisition

- Sell to buyers that already have a site-control pipeline.
- Later partner with licensed brokers and counsel instead of replacing them.

How to sell this gate

- "We make the option clock correspond to the evidence clock."
- Never imply legal advice or brokerage authority you do not possess.

What the company looks like

- Small service firm; no land inventory required.
- Maintain licensed partner network.

Gate 5 - Utility and power path

Gate question: Is there a credible path to the required quantity, quality, price, reliability and date of power?

Verdict: Essential gate, but never claim engineering capability without engineers.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
Atwell / B&V / Stantec / Burns & McDonnell / AECOM	Power diligence, utility coordination, grid studies, substation/transmission design.	Very high	Orchestrate and translate; expert owns technical conclusion.
Paces	Power-flow studies and grid-potential analysis.	High	Evidence ladder and utility-specific commercial process.
LandGate	Capacity/interconnection and upgrade-cost analysis.	High	Verification and transferability.
JLL/C&W/CBRE/Colliers	Power procurement, utility relationships and powered-land advice.	High commercial	Independent red-team plus structured utility record.

Capital deployment

- Spend $10k-$40k building a retained power-expert bench, tariff models and utility-process library.
- Formal studies/deposits are project costs and can be very large; customer or capital partner should fund them.

Customer acquisition

- Sell to developers before formal utility spend: application-readiness, tariff model, study-scope review.
- Use paid experts in sales calls; founder remains project/evidence lead.

How to sell this gate

- "We do not manufacture MW. We make the utility path legible and auditable."
- Show an evidence ladder from nearby infrastructure to executed service documents.

What the company looks like

- At ~$500k-$1m annual revenue, retain a senior utility/power lead; full-time only when utilization supports it.
- Office can remain small; expertise matters more than headcount.

Gate 6 - Physical, environmental and resource feasibility

Gate question: Can the facility actually be built and operated?

Verdict: High-value coordination layer; professional conclusions remain outsourced until scale warrants hires/acquisitions.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
AECOM/Atwell/Kimley-Horn/ Stantec/B&V	Civil, geotech, environmental, water, permitting, infrastructure and field studies.	Very high	Scope normalization and integrated evidence.
Paces/LandGate	Desktop environmental/site constraints.	High early stage	Escalation rules from desktop signal to professional proof.
Specialist environmental/water firms	Phase I/II, wetlands, water, air, species, cultural, wastewater.	High licensed/specialist	Coordinate sequence and avoid duplicative studies.

Capital deployment

- Spend $10k-$30k on master scopes, consultant panel and bid-comparison system.
- Customer funds field studies. Do not internalize laboratories, drilling or surveying early.

Customer acquisition

- Sell a diligence-orchestration package after a site survives Gate 5.
- Make consultant procurement itself a savings proposition.

How to sell this gate

- "One risk register, not eight disconnected reports."

- Translate every report into decision, dependency, expiration and next action.

What the company looks like

- 3-8 employees can support project management/data while specialists remain external.
- Office: modest Tucson suite if team is local; otherwise hybrid.

Gate 7 - Entitlement and political durability

Gate question: Can approvals be obtained and survive politics, appeals and community opposition?

Verdict: Excellent recurring-revenue opportunity; local specificity is defensible.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
Atwell/Kimley-Horn/AECOM	Zoning, entitlement management, agency coordination and community engagement.	High	Continuous political/docket monitoring + evidence integration.
Brokerages/developers	Local government relationships and incentive/development agreements.	High	Independent stakeholder/risk map.
Tract	Early community engagement and planned data-center parks.	Very high at scale	Smaller-market intelligence and monitoring.
Law/land-use/public-affairs firms	Entitlements, hearings, litigation and communications.	High licensed work	Coordinate, monitor and preserve record.

Capital deployment

- Spend $5k-$25k on docket/agenda monitoring, local counsel and community-relations partners.
- Do not buy lobbying infrastructure early.

Customer acquisition

- Sell monitoring subscriptions to owners with sites already under control.
- Use local ordinance/rate-case changes as trigger-based outbound.

How to sell this gate

- "Political risk is a site condition."
- Present facts, stakeholder map and mitigation options; avoid pretending you can guarantee approvals.

What the company looks like

- Add permitting/political analyst after recurring monitoring revenue.
- At 8-15 employees, dedicated Tucson office becomes sensible if Arizona remains core market.

Gate 8 - Integrated business case

Gate question: Does the combined site still make financial sense?

Verdict: Strong product if evidence from prior gates is proprietary and well organized.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
CBRE/JLL/C&W/Colliers	Underwriting, valuation, capital markets, site strategy.	High	Evidence-grounded site-specific risk model.
Engineering firms	Conceptual cost/schedule and feasibility.	High	Combine specialist outputs into one investment-committee decision.
LandGate/Paces	Economic/site analysis.	Medium-high	Use verified actual inputs rather than generic assumptions.

Capital deployment

- Spend $10k-$30k on financial-model templates and senior project-finance/rate review.
- Avoid complex proprietary software until repeated paid cases expose common structure.

Customer acquisition

- Sell investment-committee memos and red-team reviews to developers/investors.
- Price against avoided diligence and bad-site carrying cost, not pages produced.

How to sell this gate

- "We convert technical diligence into an invest/hold/kill decision."
- Always show downside cases and unresolved assumptions.

What the company looks like

- 5-15 employees: research, PM, finance/modeling, BD plus expert network.
- This is where a real operating company begins to emerge.

Gate 9 - Transferable evidence and commercial readiness

Gate question: Can a buyer, lender or investment committee independently audit and reuse the work?

Verdict: Potential core moat and recurring-revenue engine.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
Virtual data-room providers	Store documents securely.	Low	They store files; they do not determine what each file proves.
Engineering/brokerage firms	Produce reports and transaction materials.	Medium	Cross-firm provenance, expiration and reliance map.
Paces/LandGate	Generate diligence reports and integrated project data.	High	Permissioned evidence graph + human validation history.

Capital deployment

- Spend $10k-$50k on secure workflow/data architecture after customers prove demand.
- Do not build a full SaaS platform before recurring revenue; start with existing VDR/CRM/database tools.

Customer acquisition

- Bundle Passport with monitoring subscription.
- Target portfolio owners, lenders and capital partners who repeatedly re-underwrite sites.

How to sell this gate

- "The product is not a PDF. It is the chain of proof behind the decision."
- Show source, date, scope, confidence, expiration, transferability and next proof for each material claim.

What the company looks like

- At $1m+ annual revenue and ~50% recurring, hire data engineer/product lead.
- 10-25 employees; dedicated office plus remote specialists becomes reasonable.

Gate 10 - Closing, construction, energization and lifecycle

Gate question: Can the project execute through construction and operation?

Verdict: Long-term expansion, not launch product.

Competitors already doing this

Competitor	What they do	Overlap	Opening
Tract / major developers	Own and execute development.	Very high	Synchronicity should not initially compete.
AECOM/Atwell/B&V/large EPCs	Engineering, construction, commissioning and utility interfaces.	Very high	Evidence/milestone operating layer only.
CBRE/JLL/C&W	Project management, facility operations, transactions.	High	Owner-side evidence continuity and monitoring.

Capital deployment

- Do not deploy construction capital from the service company at early stages.
- Only enter direct development after strong balance sheet, experienced executives and project-level capital partners.

Customer acquisition

- Sell lifecycle monitoring to customers created in earlier gates.
- Long term, use proprietary site intelligence to co-develop selectively.

How to sell this gate

- "We stay with the evidence from first screen through energization."
- Do not claim EPC or operating competence until it exists.

What the company looks like

- 10-100 employees only after ~$3m-$10m+ revenue/ARR, repeatable multi-market demand and institutional capital.
- A larger facility is justified by real teams/functions, not image. Direct land/development capital should sit in separate project entities/funds.

Founder myth without dishonesty

The useful version of "fake it until you make it" is not pretending to have experience, clients, capacity or credentials. It is adopting the operating behavior, presentation standards and risk discipline of the company you intend to become before you have its scale.

- Build the myth around a true obsession: "I started Synchronicity after discovering that the most valuable powered-land facts were exactly the facts public datasets could not prove."
- Use a visible doctrine: Signals are not proof. Kill weak sites early. Every claim has a source. Every unknown has a next verification step.
- Borrow credibility transparently: an advisory bench of named licensed experts, paid per engagement. Say "reviewed by" only when it was actually reviewed.
- Publish narrow, technically careful field notes. Corrections increase credibility when made promptly.
- Look institutional through process: domain email, concise website, standard proposal, branded Passport, secure data room, written methodology, version control, conflicts policy, professional insurance, prompt follow-up.
- Do not fabricate an office, team, customer logos, utility relationships, partnerships, proprietary capacity, case studies, or testimonials. Do not call a contractor an employee or adviser without agreement.

Company scale and office gates

Stage	Revenue/capital gate	People	Physical footprint	Capital posture
0 - validation	$0-$75k cumulative revenue; <$10k-$20k founder capital at risk	Founder + hourly experts	Apartment/home + meeting rooms/coworking	Buy learning, data and expert review.
1 - repeatable service	~$20k-$25k monthly revenue for 3 months; 3+ paying customers	Founder + 1 research/GIS analyst	Coworking or very small Tucson office only if useful	$15k-$35k operating budget; no speculative land.
2 - small firm	$300k-$750k annualized; 6	2-5 employees + expert	Small professional Tucson	Invest in CRM, data, travel,

	months runway; repeat work	bench	office	monitoring and sales.
3 - expert-led	$1m+ annual revenue; ~50% recurring; 20+ accepted Passports	5-15 employees; retained/full-time power and permitting leads	Dedicated Tucson office; hybrid specialist network	Possible $1m-$2.5m raise to scale proven demand.
4 - platform	$2m-$5m ARR; strong renewals; 50+ monitored sites	15-40 employees: product/data/sales/experts	Larger office; multi-market presence	Build evidence graph/API; selective project SPVs.
5 - institutional	$5m-$15m+ revenue/ARR and institutional backing	40-100+ employees	Larger HQ + regional offices as needed	Deploy substantial project capital through separate vehicles; possible acquisitions.

Office rule: do not use rent as a credibility prop. A customer should infer seriousness from the work product, expert bench and evidence discipline. A two-employee Tucson office is reasonable around the small-firm stage if both people are local and customer/vendor meetings justify it. A 10-100 person facility belongs after product-market fit, not before it.

How to sell the company at every stage

- Lead with the customer loss you prevent: false-positive sites, duplicated diligence, stale evidence and capital spent before fatal flaws are known.
- Ask: "What evidence would your investment committee need before it treats this site as real?" Then build backward from that answer.
- For an inexperienced founder objection: "Do not underwrite my biography. Audit the process, the sources and the specialists responsible for each conclusion. Start with a fixed-scope pilot."
- For the competitor objection: "We do not replace your engineer, broker or lawyer. We make sure you hire the right one at the right time and that their work remains usable in the next decision."
- For the middleman objection: "A middleman passes introductions. We change the decision state: requirements become gates, claims become evidence, unknowns become verification tasks, and weak sites die before expensive diligence."
- For the speculative-startup objection: "The company begins as a cash-generating service. Software and land capital follow only after customers repeatedly pay for the workflow."

Capital deployment rule

Every dollar should purchase one of four assets: customer learning, proprietary verified information, repeatable workflow, or distribution. If it purchases appearance alone, defer it. Early capital should therefore favor expert reviews, data, travel to high-value calls, professional insurance, secure information systems and paid pilots. Land options, custom software, large offices and full-time specialists come later.

Research notes and sources

Project-file basis. The Arizona screening files report 255 evaluated candidates, 166 on private land, unknown substation capacity for 248 candidates, ambiguous overlapping utility territories for 181 candidates, and a point-not-parcel limitation. The water notes expressly warn that a 20/20 score means regulatory freedom rather than physical water. The viability report argues that value premiums attach primarily to entitlements and utility commitments, not consultant reports. These findings informed the recommended evidence-first model.

Web competitor research (accessed August 29, 2026): Paces - paces.com; LandGate - landgate.com; DC Byte - dcbyte.com; Tract - tract.com; Atwell - atwell.com; AECOM - aecom.com; Black & Veatch - bv.com; Kimley-Horn - kimley-horn.com; Burns & McDonnell - burnsmcd.com; CBRE - cbre.com; JLL - jll.com; Cushman & Wakefield - cushmanwakefield.com; Colliers - colliers.com. Colliers 2026 powered-land research reports national powered-land premiums and emphasizes committed power plus entitlements; its 2026 market report also identifies power certainty and execution as primary differentiators.

Important limitation. Competitor websites describe marketed capabilities, not every detail of actual client engagements. The gap analysis is therefore strategic inference from public offerings, not a claim that no competitor has ever built a similar internal evidence workflow.

This document is a business-strategy analysis, not legal, engineering, brokerage, securities, tax or investment advice.